

LING 102 section week 5 (2/23)

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1 Referential expressions

There are broadly three types of referential expressions (i.e. NPs) cross-linguistically:

- (1) a. **anaphors**: makes reference to another referential expression present in the sentence
e.g. reflexives (*myself, himself, herself, themselves*), reciprocals (*each other*)
- b. **pronouns**: optionally makes reference to another referential expression
e.g. *I/me/my, you/your/yours, he/him/his, she/her/hers, they/them*
- c. **R-expressions**: names, descriptions, etc. referring to entities in the world
e.g. *Luna, the cat, Harvard, Professor Huang's dog, the problem set*

If an anaphor/pronoun makes reference to another referential expression in the sentence, that expression is called the **antecedent**. We then say that the antecedent and the anaphor/pronoun are **coreferential** (or **coindexed**), meaning that they refer to the same entity.

- (2) a. *He_i saw himself_i* _____ is the antecedent of the {anaphor/pronoun} _____
- b. *Luna_i licked her_i paw* _____ is the antecedent of the {anaphor/pronoun} _____
- (3) a. *He_i saw himself_i* are *I* and *myself* coreferential? yes ☐ no ☐ sometimes ☐
- b. *He_i saw him_j* are *he* and *him* coreferential? yes ☐ no ☐ sometimes ☐
- c. *Luna_i licked her_{i/j} paw* are *Luna* and *her* coreferential? yes ☐ no ☐ sometimes ☐
- d. *She_i licked Luna_j* are *her* and *Luna* coreferential? yes ☐ no ☐ sometimes ☐

2 Binding

The grammatical distribution of referential expressions is related to a concept called binding:

- (4) **binding**: α binds β if and only if: 1) α c-commands β and 2) α and β are coreferential.
if α binds β , β is called a **bound** expression (as opposed to a **free** expression)
- (5) a. **principle A**: an anaphor must be *bound* in its local binding domain
- b. **principle B**: a pronoun must be *free* in its local binding domain
- c. **principle C**: an R-expression must be completely *free* in any binding domain

For now, we can think of **local binding domain** as the most immediate sentence (S) dominating a referential expression, if that referential expression constitutes the entire NP argument.

- (6) In the following, explain why each sentence is (un)grammatical given the binding rules:
 - a. [_S John and Bill_i praised each other_i]

b. *[_S John and Bill_i said that [_S Mary praised each other_i]]

c. *[_S John_i criticized him_i]

d. [_S John_i said that [_S Mary criticized him_i]]

e. *[_S John_i loves John_i]

f. *[_S John_i said that [_S Mary loves John_i]]

If a referential expression is embedded within a complex NP (e.g. a possessive, which itself has the structure of NP+'s that contains another NP), then the local binding domain is the complex NP.

(7) a. [_S John_i likes [_{NP} his_i cat]]

b. [_S John_i said that [_S Mary likes his_i cat]]

3 Negative polarity items (NPIs)

Special words like *any*, *anything*, *anyone*, *anywhere*, *at all*, *ever* and *anymore* in English are called negative polarity items (NPIs), and are licensed (i.e. possible) in downward entailing contexts:

(8) a. **NPI licensing:** an NPI must occur in a downward entailing context

b. **downward entailing context:** an environment which within the c-command domain of 1) negation, 2) a yes-no question, or 3) an *if*-conditional

(9) Turn the following ungrammatical sentence into a grammatical one:

a. **Sasha went to school at all.* (use negation)

- b. **Sasha ever turn in her homework.* (use a yes-no question)

- c. **Sasha goes anywhere for spring break.* (use an *if*-conditional)

In other languages, NPIs are sometimes derived from existing words in the lexicon.

- (10) Indonesian (Austronesian)
 - a. apa yang kamu makan?
what that 2SG eat
'What did you eat?'
 - b. saya tidak makan apa-apa
1SG NEG eat what-what
'I didn't eat anything.'
 - c. siapa yang kamu lihat?
who that 2SG see
'Who did you see?'
 - d. saya tidak me-lihat siapa-siapa
1SG NEG AV-see who-who
'I didn't see anybody.'
 - e. ke mana yang kamu pergi?
to where that 2SG go
'Where did you go?'

- (11) a. describe the method that Indonesian uses to create NPIs

- b. translate the following sentence to Indonesian: *I didn't go anywhere.*